

VAI Strategy 2024–29

Introduction

This is a draft strategic framework for Victim Advocates International (VAI) for 2024–29. As we enter our second five-year period, we are aiming to become a stronger, more impactful, and more sustainable organisation.

The strategy has two parts:

- Part 1 articulates the core proposition of VAI – our mission, our high-level goals and objectives, and the approach we take to achieving them. This is the why, what, and how of VAI.
- Part 2 explains how we aim to develop and change over the next five years as we seek to deepen our roots and become a more sustainable organisation.

Part 1: Our proposition

Mission statement

The mission statement of the organisation is as follows:

“Victim Advocates International empowers victims of serious international crimes and transforms accountability processes. Working alongside victim groups, we support them to get justice that matters to them.”

“All too often, victims are not included in legal processes. At Victim Advocates International, we strive to amplify their voices, ensuring they are heard and respected on the global stage.”

“We want to disrupt existing systems. Our goal is for victims to have the power and agency to create their own path towards healing and justice.”

Our goals and objectives

Based on the mission statement, the following broad goals articulate what VAI is aiming to achieve in the world. Each one is broken down into more specific objectives that describe the dimensions of change. These objectives are the basis for measuring the impact of our work towards the larger goals.

GOAL 1: Victims of serious international crimes secure outcomes in line with their conception of justice.

Our first and most important goal is to ensure that victims of serious international crimes are able to secure outcomes, including meaningful legal remedies, that are based on their own conception and articulation of what justice looks like for them. This is our driving ambition and the reason we exist as an organisation.

Objectives:

- **1.1. Shifts in agency:** Victims of serious international crimes are able to articulate their conception of justice and make informed decisions about how to seek it.
- **1.2. Delivery of justice outcomes:** Victims ultimately secure outcomes, either through legal channels or other routes, that reflect their own conception of justice.

GOAL 2: Victims of serious international crimes are empowered by the process of pursuing justice.

Our second goal is to ensure that the process of pursuing justice leaves victims of serious international crimes empowered. While legal outcomes may take a long time to achieve, our clients should benefit from having a direct stake in pursuing them.

Objectives:

- **2.1. Shifts in knowledge:** Clients have greater knowledge and understanding of legal options and processes, and more confidence to pursue them.
- **2.2. Shifts in engagement:** All clients are engaged and informed throughout the entire process.

GOAL 3: Justice processes in the wake of international crimes are transformed so as to put victims at the centre.

Our third goal is to disrupt existing practices and ensure that victims are put at the centre of justice processes following serious international crimes. We want our model of victim representation to become the standard for others working in the same field.

Objectives:

- **3.1. Conceptual shifts:** The concept of high-quality, individualised legal representation for victims of serious international crimes is widely recognised as a necessary shift.
- **3.2. Behavioural shifts:** Our model is adopted by others working in the field of international justice.

Hierarchy of goals



Our approach

Our approach in seeking to achieve these goals is as follows:

- Our work begins by helping our clients to articulate their own conception of justice and to understand the legal avenues available to pursue it.
- We are flexible in how we fulfil the instructions of our clients, and we pride ourselves on our versatility and problem-solving approach.
- Where possible, we take up cases directly on behalf of our clients. Where this is not appropriate, usually for reasons of capacity or jurisdiction, we identify and instruct lawyers who are suitably qualified and authorised to practise.
- We work in partnership with others who complement our approach, including in the context of international advocacy and campaigning around mass atrocity crimes.

Our core capabilities

We will maintain and cultivate the following core capabilities within VAI. They will be components of our offering in any context in which we work.

1. Criminal litigation
2. Civil litigation
3. Mediation
4. Community engagement and training

Part 2: Our next five years

Context

The next five years are a crucial period of growth for VAI in which we will aim to strengthen our roots, expand our reach, and become sustainable for the longer term. This section sets out how we aim to do this.

Priorities for growth

1. We will build a well-structured and sustainable organisation.

We will strengthen the organisation over the coming five years. This will include the following shifts:

- Developing a strong leadership structure within the organisation, including programmatic management and operations management under the overall leadership of the Executive Director.
- Embedding core functions within the organisation that are reflected in the job descriptions of existing or new staff or outsourced as appropriate: spokesperson(s), communications, and development.
- Building a new governance structure, including Trustees and a wider Advisory Board. Trustees will have clear roles and will be expected to provide fiduciary and strategic oversight of the organisation as a charity registered in the UK. Members of the Advisory Board will be asked to guide our substantive work and identify opportunities for impact.

We will ensure that the organisation values excellence and rigour and has clear accountability processes in place.

2. We will implement our model in new geographies.

We will build on our record with Rohingya communities in Bangladesh by implementing our model with victims of serious international crimes in other geographies.

We are not setting a target for the number of places where we will work as this will be driven by need and the opportunity to add value. But we will become ready to take up the opportunities when they arise. We will establish a replicable model and costing for each new place in which we work. It will include the following core elements:

- Local lawyer
- Community engagement specialist
- Specialist legal trainer for clients
- Fixer

Note that one individual could offer more than one of these skillsets, so this is not necessarily an indicator of the size of the team.

3. We will tell our story well.

In line with our ambition to establish our model of victim representation as the global standard, we will invest in telling our story well to our wider sector. This will be facilitated partly by our new brand identity. We will make the case for our approach and demonstrate its impact. In order to facilitate this, we will build a new communications function within VAI and embed a storytelling approach to describing our organisational impact.